

FANTASIA II



Sym and Vima • Imprisoned • Soul

Fantasia II

Fantasia II

Dedicated to All of Humanity

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Sym and Vima

A Mythic Fantasy Tale



*Before the gods learned their names,
Love learned how to answer yes.*

I — The First Children of the Universe

Before the time of gods and heroes, before kings divided the earth with roads and walls, the Universe made its first children. They were called the Invi.

The Invi had no bodies that stone could stop, no feet that dust could remember, and no hands that could bend a blade of grass. They moved through mountains as easily as wind through an open door. Rain passed through them. Fire neither warmed nor burned them. They could see the visible world in all its bright abundance, yet they could not touch a single part of it.

At first they considered this freedom. Nothing could imprison them. No beast could bite them, no winter could freeze them, and no cliff could make them fall. But freedom without consequence soon became another kind of prison. They watched fruit ripen and could not taste it. They listened to rivers and could not feel the water. They crossed sleeping villages and saw families gathered around fires, sharing bread,

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arguments, songs, and silence. The Invi could pass through every home in the world, but they belonged in none of them.

So they made a main village of their own in a valley hidden between two hills. Its houses were not built of timber or stone, for such things would ignore their hands. They built instead with memory, agreement, and imagination. A doorway existed because everyone remembered where it was. A roof kept out no rain, but it gave a room its shape. A chair held no weight, yet an Invi could sit upon it by deciding that sitting was what they were doing.

They called the village Elun, which in their oldest speech meant the place where voices remain. Voices were the one gift the Universe had given them generously. The Invi could hear one another, and so they talked. They told stories that lasted years. They invented games with rules so complicated that nobody ever truly won. They argued over whether the moon looked lonely or merely proud. Above all, they kept one another company, because conversation was the nearest thing they had to touch.

Among them lived Vima, whose name meant toward. Other Invi were content to drift through the visible world and return with descriptions. Vima wanted more. She wanted the

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world not only to pass before her eyes, but to answer her presence. She would stand beneath apple trees and imagine their branches bending under her hand. She would follow potters and ache to leave one thumbprint in wet clay. When birds landed on stones, she whispered to them, though they never turned their heads.

The elders warned her that longing could become a wound. Vima answered that perhaps a wound was proof that something had touched you.

The Universe heard this. The Universe heard everything, though it did not always listen kindly.

II — The Aena

The Universe had grown troubled by its first children. It had made them safe, and safety had made them sorrowful. So, as the Universe often did, it offered mercy with a devious condition.

It created a second people: the Aena. They were as solid as the Invi were untouchable. Their feet pressed paths into soil. Their hands raised homes, planted fields, carved flutes, mended wounds, and sometimes caused them. They could taste berries, feel sunlight, embrace one another, and drown in deep water. Yet the Aena could not see the unseen world at all. An Invi might stand beside an Aena for a hundred years and remain no more visible than a forgotten thought.

To each Aena, the Universe bound one perfect Invi match, and to each Invi one Aena. It placed them far apart, scattered across forests, islands, deserts, and cities not yet built. It gave neither tribe a map. If a pair found one another and learned to love despite the wall between their worlds, and if their love

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remained pure when power came near it, the wall would break. They would rise together beyond mortality and become Gods.

The Universe told no one.

Perhaps it wished to see whether love discovered freely was stronger than love pursued as a prize. Perhaps it feared what its children would do if they knew godhood could be won. Or perhaps the Universe simply enjoyed setting riddles in motion and watching lives become their answers.

Generations passed. The Aena grew into villages and kingdoms. The Invi wandered among them, sometimes mistaking fascination for destiny, sometimes waiting beside one person for decades only to feel no answering pull. No pair crossed the divide.

Vima knew none of this. She knew only that the visible world called to her with unbearable beauty.

III — The Lake of Leth

One morning, after helping with the chores of Elun—chores that changed nothing except the order of their thoughts—Vima left the village to bathe in the Lake of Leth.

An Invi did not need bathing. Dust could not cling to her, and water could not wash her. Still, the lake was a beloved ritual. The Invi would walk beneath its surface and pretend the cold embraced them. They watched fish pass through their ribs and reeds sway through their arms. For a little while, imagination became almost sensation.

Vima reached the shore at dawn. Mist floated low over the water. The rising sun turned every drop of dew into a tiny flame. She was about to step into the lake when she saw a young Aena kneeling near the reeds.

A deer stood before him.

The animal was wild, yet it showed no fear. The young man held slices of pear in an open palm and spoke so softly that Vima could not hear the words over the water. His hair was

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dark and untidy from sleep. His clothes were plain, patched carefully at one elbow. When the deer finished eating, he did not try to touch it. He simply bowed his head as if thanking it for its trust.

Vima had seen beautiful Aena before. Beauty was common in a world that could be touched. But kindness changed the air around this one. It seemed to her that the morning light gathered upon him not because the sun had risen there, but because it wished to.

She moved closer. A strange certainty filled her—not knowledge, not yet, but recognition without memory. Every restless desire she had carried all her life became quiet. Then, in the quiet, one wish remained.

See me.

She called to him. He did not turn. She stood directly before him and shouted his own kindness back into his face. He looked through her toward the lake.

Despair rose quickly, but Vima had never been skilled at surrender. She searched the shore for anything that might

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answer her. Stones ignored her. Water ignored her. The reeds trembled only for the wind.

Then she remembered the mirrors.

IV — A Language of Light

Invi mirrors were among the oldest objects in Elun. No one knew who had made them. They could not be lifted by Aena hands, yet unlike everything else belonging to the Invi, they could catch sunlight and throw it back into the visible world.

The elders used them for ceremonies and for marking the slow passage of seasons. Vima had used one as a child to scatter gold across the walls of an imaginary house. Never had any Invi thought of sunlight as a bridge.

She ran from the lake, through hills and trees and half a mountain, until she reached Elun. She seized the nearest mirror from the Hall of First Voices. Elder Sava shouted after her, but Vima was already gone.

When she returned, the young man was still beside the lake, tying a strip of cloth around the cracked branch of a sapling. Vima raised the mirror. Her hands could hold it because it belonged to her world; the sun could touch it because sunlight belonged, perhaps, to every world.

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She aimed.

A blade of brightness struck the young man in the eyes.

He cried out, stumbled backward, and nearly fell into the lake. Vima lowered the mirror in horror. The deer vanished into the forest.

The young man rubbed his eyes. Then he looked toward the place where the light had come from. There was no glass, no polished metal, no standing figure. The beam had appeared from empty air.

His fear lasted only a moment. Curiosity replaced it.

“Is someone there?” he asked.

Vima nearly dropped the mirror.

She flashed the light wildly across the water.

He watched the reflections dance. “An Invi?”

Again, she flashed the lake.

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Stories of the unseen people survived among the Aena as children's tales: voices in empty rooms, laughter beneath old bridges, sunlight moving without cause. Most adults dismissed them. The young man did not.

He sat cross-legged on the shore and considered the problem with the seriousness of a scholar and the delight of a child.

"We need rules," he said. "Light the surface of the lake once for yes. Leave it dark for no. Can you do that?"

A bright circle appeared beside him.

He smiled. "Good. My name is Sym."

Vima shone light on the water, though he had asked no question. It was the only answer she had.

That first conversation was clumsy. Was she near him? Yes. Had she lived by the lake? No. Could she hear him? Yes. Could she speak? Yes. Could he hear her? No. Was she alone? No. Was she dangerous? Vima hesitated so long that Sym laughed.

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“I suppose everyone is dangerous in the right circumstances,” he said. “Let me ask better. Do you mean me harm?”

No light touched the lake.

Sym remained until noon. Before leaving he said, “Will you be here tomorrow?”

The lake blazed.

V — Questions

Sym came the next morning, and the morning after that.

He worked in a village beyond the eastern ridge as a healer's apprentice. His teacher, Maya, believed every wound asked a question of the body and every cure was an answer offered carefully. Sym brought that same patience to Vima.

He began with questions that could be solved by yes or no, but soon built whole ladders from them. Was her name one syllable? No. Two? Yes. Did it begin with a sound made by closing the lips? Yes. He recited names until her light flashed at Vima. She learned his past through similar games. His mother had died when he was young. His father shaped wooden bowls. Sym loved animals, hated turnips, feared deep caves, and secretly wrote songs he was too embarrassed to sing.

They devised a wider language. One flash meant yes. Darkness meant no. Two quick flashes meant repeat. A long beam meant laughter. A wandering circle meant confusion. Three bright pulses meant danger. Sym scratched letters into

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the mud and pointed to them while Vima answered. With time, she learned to spell by reflecting light onto each mark.

Their first true sentence took an entire afternoon.

I AM GLAD YOU CAME.

Sym read it aloud twice. His voice changed on the second reading.

“So am I,” he said.

The Invi of Elun thought Vima had gone mad. Some followed her to the lake and watched the conversations. They were astonished, then frightened. Elder Sava warned that attracting the notice of the visible might bring ruin. Vima asked whether an untouched life could truly be ruined.

Others began to hope. They carried questions for Sym: Did Aena dream in color? Did bread taste as warm as it smelled? Could a hand remember another hand after letting go? Vima asked some of them, but she guarded her hours with Sym jealously. The lake had become the one place in the world where she was not merely an observer.

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Sym began bringing objects. He placed them at the water's edge and described them as though she had never seen them: a red apple, a copper bell, a wool scarf, a carved fox. Vima had seen a thousand apples, bells, scarves, and foxes. But through Sym's descriptions, she learned what weight felt like, what cold metal did to a palm, how wool scratched gently at the throat, how an apple cracked between teeth and released sweetness.

In return, Vima showed him what only the unseen could know. She reflected light toward hidden springs beneath stone. She warned him when storms gathered beyond the mountains. She led him to lost animals and once to a child trapped in an abandoned well. Sym told the villagers he followed instinct. He did not know how to explain a friend made of silence and sunlight.

Days became weeks. Their questions grew less careful.

"Are you beautiful?" Sym asked one evening.

The lake stayed dark.

"That was not an answer."

A wandering circle of confusion moved over the water.

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He smiled. “Then I will decide you are.”

A long beam swept across the lake: laughter, though Vima’s heart trembled.

VI — What the Heart Desires

At the end of summer, Sym asked the question that changed everything.

The evening was warm, and insects hummed over the reeds. Sym had brought two cups of berry tea out of habit. He drank from one and placed the other beside him for Vima, although both knew she could not lift it.

“What do you desire most in this world?” he asked. “Tell me, and I will bring it.”

Vima’s mirror lowered.

The answer was so large that yes and no could not hold it. She desired to feel the cup’s warmth. She desired to hear her own footsteps. She desired to place her hand over Sym’s and know where he ended and she began. But beneath all these desires lived one older than language: she wanted the world to meet her.

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Sym began to guess.

“Gold?” No.

“A crown?” No.

“A house of your own?” No.

“Music?” No, though she sent a long flash to soften the answer.

“To be heard?” She almost said yes, but hearing was not enough.

Each day he returned with new guesses. A feast. A horse. A book. A name remembered by everyone. The freedom to travel. The ability to dream. A garden. A child. A body.

At that last word, Vima’s mirror shook, scattering light in broken pieces. Sym saw, but the lake did not give him the clear circle of yes.

Days passed. His confidence faded. Sometimes he sat in silence, afraid that she had left. He would call her name, and Vima would answer at once, covering the lake with light.

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One dawn, after nearly a month, Sym arrived exhausted. He had not slept. He stared at the pale horizon and spoke guesses without hope.

“The moon. The stars. The sea. The sky.”

No.

The sun rose behind him.

Sym looked at its reflection stretching across the lake like a golden road.

“The Sun?”

Vima lifted the mirror. She didn’t know exactly why, but this was the correct answer.

A perfect circle of light appeared on the water.

Sym fell silent.

“How can I bring you the Sun?”

Vima had no answer. But, deep inside, she knew he could do it. The light faded from the lake.

VII — The Longest Night

Sym returned to his village with the impossible request inside him.

He climbed onto the roof of his father's workshop and watched the sun cross the sky. He considered mirrors, flames, polished bowls, amber, and glass. None was the Sun. A flame could warm but not rise. A mirror could borrow light but not keep it. Even kings could not command morning.

Maya found him there after dark.

"Some wounds cannot be closed," she said.

"Then what does a healer do?"

"Stays beside them."

Sym thought of Vima standing beside every beautiful thing and feeling none of it. He thought of the unused cup of tea, the apple she could see but never taste, and the way her light answered his name before he finished speaking it.

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“What if staying is not enough?”

Maya looked at him carefully. “Then you give what the wound is truly asking for, not what its words appear to demand.”

Sym did not sleep. Near midnight he wandered through the fields beyond the village. The moon silvered rows of grain. At the edge of an abandoned garden, something tall moved in the wind.

A sunflower faced east, waiting faithfully for a dawn that had not yet come.

Sym stopped.

The flower held no fire, yet it carried the Sun’s shape. Its yellow petals surrounded a dark center like rays around the mystery of light. It could be taken beneath a roof, into a cave, through rain, or into the hand of someone who had never felt morning.

He laughed aloud. Then he asked the flower’s forgiveness and cut it gently at the stem.

VIII — The Gift

Sym reached the Lake of Leth before sunrise. Vima was already there.

She had feared he would not return. The request now seemed foolish to her, a child's answer to a question too generous to refuse. When he came running down the path with mud on his boots and a flower in his hand, relief moved through her so powerfully that the mist swirled around her invisible form.

Sym stood at the shore, breathless.

"I could not bring the Sun," he said. "Not the one in the sky. It belongs to everyone, and perhaps to no one."

Vima lowered her mirror.

"But I brought you a sun that can go anywhere."

He placed the sunflower carefully upon the lake.

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It floated between them. The first edge of dawn appeared over the hills. Vima caught it in her mirror and reflected it onto the flower. Gold burst from the petals. Ripples widened across the surface, breaking the light into a thousand dancing pieces.

For the first time, Vima did not envy the visible world. She felt answered by it. The flower could not enter her hands, yet it existed because Sym had heard the truth inside an impossible wish. He had not given her the Sun. He had given her proof that he understood why she wanted it.

The water rippled though there was no wind.

Sym watched the light scatter around him. Every bright shard seemed to carry Vima's laughter.

He knelt and touched the sunflower.

"I love you," he said.

Then he bent and kissed its golden petals.

The Universe, which had watched civilizations rise and fall without blinking, held its breath.

I X — S e e n

The lake became still.

The reflected lights gathered from the water and lifted into the air. They circled Sym like fireflies, then moved toward an empty place before him. One by one they settled upon the outline of a woman.

First he saw her hands around the mirror. Then her face, her dark hair, and her eyes wide with concentration. Morning colored her gently, as though dawn had been waiting since creation to reveal her.

Vima did not realize that anything had changed. She kept angling the mirror toward the sunflower, trying to answer his confession with all the light she could gather.

Sym stood.

She saw him approaching and moved the beam aside, confused. He came closer than ever before. No Aena had willingly walked toward her gaze. He lifted one hand.

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His fingers touched her cheek.

The sensation was small. Warm skin. A slight trembling.
The pressure of five fingertips.

It was greater than mountains.

Vima gasped. Her voice entered the visible world as sound
for the first time.

“Sym?”

He laughed and began to cry at once. “You are here.”

“I was always here.”

“I know.”

He kissed her.

The kiss was the sweetest thing Vima had ever tasted, though she had tasted nothing before. It was warmth and breath, wonder and recognition. The entire visible world arrived through that single point of contact: rain, fruit, fire, pain, shelter, hunger, music, and every embrace she had watched from beyond reach.

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She dropped the mirror. It did not fall. It dissolved into sunlight. Power rose around them.

X — The Test of Power

Physis (the Universe) had promised infinite power, but it did not grant it gently.

The sky opened above the lake, revealing not clouds but the vast machinery of creation: stars being born, seas gathering, mountains rising from fire. Knowledge poured into Vima and Sym. They understood how to call storms, halt time, heal any wound, shape creatures from thought, and reduce kingdoms to ash.

They felt every prayer that would one day be spoken. They saw temples built in their names and armies marching beneath their symbols. They saw themselves adored, feared, obeyed.

A voice without sound filled them.

Choose what you will become.

Sym looked at Vima. Vima looked at the sunflower floating on the lake.

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They could command the Sun now. They could pull it from the sky and place it in Vima's hands. Yet doing so would darken every field, freeze every child, and turn the gift that united them into possession.

Vima understood the Universe's final deception. Power did not prove love. Power asked whether love would survive the ability to own everything.

She reached for Sym's hand—not because she needed his strength, but because she desired his presence.

"I do not want the Sun," she said. "I wanted the world to answer me."

Sym squeezed her hand. "Then let us answer it."

They refused thrones. They refused worship. They refused dominion over the wills of others. Instead they chose guardianship over every border that kept two hearts apart: the border between seen and unseen, speech and silence, loneliness and recognition.

The power settled into them like calm after rain.

XI — The First Gods

When Vima and Sym opened their eyes, they stood upon the lake without sinking.

The Invi of Elun had gathered along the shore. For the first time, Sym could see them all: translucent figures shining softly in the dawn. The Aena villagers came over the eastern ridge, drawn by the light. For the first time, the two peoples looked upon one another.

Fear moved through both crowds. Then Elder Sava stepped forward. Maya did the same.

Neither could touch the other, but Vima raised her hands between them. A bridge of gold appeared, not of stone, but of shared perception. For one breath, Sava saw the wrinkles around Maya's eyes, and Maya heard the old Invi's astonished laugh.

That was enough to begin.

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Vima and Sym became the first gods, though they rarely called themselves so. They traveled the world together. Where an unheard voice searched for an answer, Vima carried it. Where someone struggled to understand a longing unlike their own, Sym brought patience. They taught the Invi and Aena new languages of bells, mirrors, shadows, ripples, dreams, and music.

Other matched souls began to find one another. Not all became gods. Some were selfish. Some mistook desire for love. Some found their match and chose different paths. The Universe never made love inevitable; it only made it possible.

But every true meeting weakened the wall between worlds.

The Lake of Leth became sacred. Sunflowers grew around it in every season, even beneath snow. Travelers left small mirrors on the shore, and those who felt unseen came to watch the dawn. Sometimes a beam of light moved across the water with no visible hand to guide it. Sometimes a lonely traveler asked a question and received one bright circle in reply.

XII — What Remains

Ages passed. Gods and heroes filled the world with famous deeds. Kingdoms rose, named themselves eternal, and disappeared. The old story of the Invi and Aena became a song, then a children's tale, then a whisper carried by people who no longer remembered why sunflowers turn toward light.

Yet Vima and Sym remained.

They did not rule from a palace. They wandered. Sometimes they appeared as two travelers sharing bread. Sometimes as light on a lake. Sometimes as the sudden courage to speak or the unexpected patience to listen.

And when a person stood near another and wondered how any true understanding could cross the distance between them, Vima would remember the first flash of sunlight thrown from an impossible place. Sym would remember a flower waiting through the longest night.

Then, quietly, they would help.

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For the first language of love was not a poem, nor a promise, nor even a kiss.

It was a question offered into silence.

And a light upon the water that answered yes.



THE END

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Imprisoned

A Novel of Waland

Prologue - White Wings

On the morning Evorn married Myca, the bells of Waland rang so loudly that snow slid from the roofs of the capital. The sound crossed the frozen river, rolled through the cedar woods, and reached the walls where soldiers in blue cloaks watched the south. It was meant to be a sound of renewal. To fifteen-year-old Raevorn, it sounded like a grave being sealed.

His mother, Erica, had been dead for three winters. She had come from Aetolia, the warm country beyond Waland's southwestern mountains, where dancers wore bells at their ankles and winter was a word used mostly in songs. Evorn had first seen her among prisoners taken in a border skirmish. He freed her and offered marriage. Erica accepted freedom, not love, though affection came later in gentler forms. She laughed at Evorn's solemn jokes. She taught Raevorn Aetolian lullabies. She planted red flowers beneath

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the palace windows and complained every year that Waland's snow was trying to murder her.

In the ninth winter of her marriage, the cold finally succeeded. Pneumonia carried her away before the thaw.

Raevorn had loved her with the absolute loyalty of a child. He remembered Evorn kneeling beside her bed, but grief had distorted the memory until it seemed that his father had merely waited for a new wife. Myca's kindness made matters worse. She never demanded to be called Mother, never moved Erica's belongings, and never spoke badly of the dead. Raevorn could have hated cruelty. He did not know what to do with patience.

The wedding filled the Church of the Four Winds with nobles, knights, alchemists, and mages. Myca wore silver rather than white, and the light around her fingers made the candles burn without smoke. Evorn looked younger when he smiled at her. Raevorn stood at his father's side and felt every blessing as an insult.

After the vows, servants carried cages into the courtyard. Hundreds of white pigeons waited inside, each bearing a

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small wedding gift for a noble house in one of Waland's provinces. At Myca's signal, the doors opened. Wings thundered upward. The birds divided beneath the pale sun and flew toward every corner of the kingdom.

No one noticed the gray dust beneath their feathers.

No one saw the thin Aetolian runes hidden beneath the ribbons around their legs.

That night, poison entered Waland on white wings.

Raevorn woke before dawn to hands dragging him from his bed. He struck one soldier and bit another before a gauntleted fist opened his lip. Through the corridor he glimpsed Myca pinned against the wall by a woman in a black veil. The witch held a needle of blue fire under Myca's fingernail and asked where the king had gone. Myca screamed but did not answer.

A hood dropped over Raevorn's head. The last thing he heard in his home was his father roaring his name.

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I - Seven Years Without Dawn

The prison erased time first.

Raevorn counted meals until hunger made numbers meaningless. He counted the changes in the sea's voice beyond his narrow window. In storms, waves struck the rock beneath the fortress like siege hammers. In calm weather, gulls cried over the water. Sometimes months passed without rain. Sometimes he woke shivering and knew winter had returned, though no snow could enter his cell.

The guards never spoke to him. Food came through a slot. Waste remained until someone opened the door wearing a leather mask and washed the stones with bitter alchemical water. Raevorn screamed questions until his voice broke. Was Waland conquered? Was Evorn alive? What had happened to Myca? Silence answered every question.

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He grew from a furious boy into a hard, underfed man. His hair reached his shoulders. His hands became knotted from striking walls. To keep from losing language, he recited every story Erica had told him. When memory failed, he invented new endings. In those endings Waland always survived.

Seven years after the wedding, a storm came from the west. Lightning struck the sea, and the prison groaned in the wind. Near dawn, the iron frame around Raevorn's window tore loose from the wall. For a moment he stared at the opening, unable to believe the world had made a mistake in his favor.

Then he heard boots in the corridor.

He climbed through the jagged hole and jumped.

The fall seemed endless. Black water swallowed him, cold enough to stop his heart. He sank, kicked blindly, and broke the surface beneath rain. The fortress rose behind him from a cliff like a rotten tooth. Bells began to ring.

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Raevorn swam until his arms no longer felt attached to him. He let the current carry him, diving whenever torchlight swept across the waves. At last his feet struck sand. He crawled into reeds and slept beneath rain with his face in the mud.

When he woke, the world smelled impossibly alive. Wet soil. Grass. Woodsmoke from a village. He wept, not from joy but because after seven years every scent hurt.

Freedom did not make him noble. It made him hungry.

He broke into an empty farmhouse, stole clothes and bread, and fled before the owners returned. The shame of it followed him for several miles, then hunger devoured the shame. He fashioned a spear from a branch and flint. He killed a wildcat badly, taking three wounds before the animal died, and ate meat so tough it made his jaw ache.

From a hill he saw a road leading north and a sign at a crossroads: TAERTHA - TOWN OF ALCHEMISTS.

He followed it because every road was better than a cell.

II - A Kingdom Renamed

Taertha smelled of vinegar, hot metal, crushed herbs, and rainwater running through gutters stained purple. Glass vessels crowded every window. Men in waxed aprons rolled barrels marked with warning sigils while women carried cages of pale insects whose wings were ground into medicine.

Raevorn found work at a warehouse by claiming that his father had thrown him out for refusing to farm. The owner, a wide woman named Orsa, looked at his starved face and did not pretend to believe him. She gave him a bowl of stew anyway.

'You can carry a pack to Rytorn,' she said. 'Bring back iron salts and moonleaf. You lose the goods, I lose nothing but bad equipment. You return, perhaps I trust you with good equipment.'

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Raevorn accepted a patched cloak, a rusted sword, and boots that pinched. He had no intention of completing the journey. What he needed was news.

He found it in taverns, markets, and queues outside ration houses. Waland had fallen after three years of war. The wedding gifts had killed or maddened hundreds of nobles, officers, court mages, and provincial governors on the same day. Aetolia invaded before Waland understood the attack. The southern fortresses opened from within. Crops burned under unnatural lightning. Wells turned sweet and poisonous.

The capital was now administered by Aetolian witches. Waland's banners were forbidden. Children were taught that the kingdom had never truly existed, only a rebellious northern province in need of civilization.

Yet the king lived.

No one knew where he was. Some said Evorn had become a wolf. Others said he had died and the resistance used his name. A merchant swore that he had seen the king lift a horse from a collapsed bridge. A drunken miner

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claimed Evorn could run beside arrows and pluck them from the air.

There were whispers of creatures too: beasts that opened prison doors, trees that repeated military plans, stone figures found in impossible places after sunrise. People called them the Imprisoned.

Raevorn followed rumor north. In each village he asked careless questions with studied indifference. In each village suspicion followed him. Aetolia paid well for informants, and the resistance answered betrayal with disappearance.

At last he reached Rytorn, a city of vineyards and iron foundries built around a black hill. An Aetolian witch named Seressa ruled from the old ducal palace. Her soldiers patrolled in lacquered armor that shed rain like oil.

Raevorn noticed a knight in a plain brown cloak moving through the poorest quarter. The knight gave coins to widows, medicine to coughing children, and bread to laborers dismissed from the foundries. At sunset, the same knight entered Seressa's palace through a guarded gate.

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Spy, Raevorn thought. Or traitor. Either might lead him to the resistance.

He followed until darkness, lost the knight near the palace, and nearly lost his sword to a stranger who caught him waiting in an alley.

'Who are you?' Raevorn demanded.

'Quiet,' the stranger hissed, forcing him behind a stack of barrels. 'Unless seven years in a cell taught you nothing about remaining unnoticed.'

Raevorn froze.

The man had a narrow face, a gray beard, and the unimpressed eyes of someone who had recognized him hours ago.

'Look at the palace,' he said.

Near dawn, small shapes climbed the walls. Some moved on four legs, some on two, and one flowed upward like a shadow poured in reverse. They settled beneath windows and along the roof. When the first sunlight touched them, they became stone.

Fantasia II

'What are they?' Raevorn whispered.

'Imprisoned,' said the man. 'People who surrendered one prison and accepted another.'

'Where is my father?'

The man punched him before his shout could summon the patrol.

III - The Coward

Raevorn woke in a cellar with a candle beside his bed and no door in the walls. A hatch opened overhead. The gray-bearded man climbed down carrying bread, cheese, and Raevorn's sword.

'My name is Tavin,' he said. 'Before you ask: your father is alive, I do not know where he is, and shouting will not improve either fact.'

Raevorn ate while Tavin explained the Chalice.

Myca had made it during the fall of the capital. Surrounded in the palace sanctuary, she had poured her magic, blood, and perhaps part of her soul into a silver ceremonial cup. Anyone who drank from it was remade. The shape could not be chosen. Some became animals, trees, statues, monsters, or things for which no language had names. Some gained strength, speed, strange senses, or command over darkness. Others died in agony.

Fantasia II

Evorn had been the first to drink. The Chalice saved his life and gave him power enough to break through Aetolia's siege. It also changed him.

'He is colder,' Tavin said. 'He sees people as pieces on a board. Sometimes he forgets that victory is supposed to save the kingdom, not consume it.'

Raevorn's hand closed around the cup of water Tavin had given him. 'Careful.'

'I have been careful for seven years. That is why I am alive.'

'Are you Imprisoned?'

Tavin looked toward the ceiling. 'No. I am a coward.'

The word carried no self-pity. That made it heavier.

Tavin had once been a palace physician. During the invasion, Myca ordered him to take the Chalice and flee. He obeyed while others stayed to die. Since then, he had guarded it, studied it, and brought volunteers to it when the resistance demanded new weapons.

Fantasia II

'You turn people into monsters and call yourself a coward?' Raevorn asked.

'Every transformation begins with a choice. I explain the danger. I never pour the drink down anyone's throat.'

'And my father?'

'He sends names.'

That evening the charitable knight entered the cellar. Without helmet and cloak she was a young woman with dark hair cut to her jaw and a burn across one cheek.

'This is Captain Letha,' Tavin said. 'She serves Witch Seressa.'

Raevorn reached for his sword.

Letha did not flinch. 'I serve the cooks, stable boys, prisoners, and families Seressa would otherwise punish. My uniform grants access. My loyalty is my own.'

She had been following Raevorn because Seressa's agents had received word of an escaped prisoner from Smyr. A description was spreading. By morning, every gate in Rytorn would be watched.

Fantasia II

'Then take me to my father tonight,' Raevorn said.

'Your father does not permit people to be taken to him. He finds them.'

As if summoned by the words, something struck the cellar hatch three times.

Tavin went pale. Letha drew her sword. The wood splintered inward, and a creature dropped into the room.

It was shaped vaguely like a man but stood too tall, with black antlers scraping the ceiling and skin that reflected no candlelight. Its eyes were Evorn's.

Raevorn knew them at once.

'Father?'

The creature's face moved as though remembering how a smile worked. 'You took your time.'

IV - The King in the Dark

Evorn could wear a human shape only by day, and even then imperfectly. At night the Chalice claimed him. He became the black-antlered hunter the resistance called the Stag King, able to cross miles in minutes, smell lies in a man's sweat, and tear iron doors from stone.

Raevorn had imagined their reunion through seven years of darkness. In every version, Evorn embraced him. Instead, his father inspected him like damaged armor.

'Thin,' Evorn said. 'Scarred. Still alive. Good.'

'Is that all?'

A flicker crossed the monster's face. 'No. But it is what matters tonight.'

They left Rytorn through forgotten aqueducts. Letha guided them beneath the walls while Tavin remained with the Chalice. Beyond the city, resistance riders waited in a

Fantasia II

ruined vineyard. Their camp moved every night, never lighting fires, never sleeping twice beneath the same roof.

Some knelt when they saw Raevorn. Others stared with disappointment, perhaps expecting a prince to emerge from prison polished and heroic. Raevorn wanted to tell them that prisons produced survivors, not symbols.

At sunrise Evorn collapsed behind a canvas screen. When he emerged, he looked human but older than Raevorn remembered. Silver ran through his hair. Black lines traced the veins around his eyes. He hugged his son at last, fiercely and briefly.

'I searched for you,' Evorn said. 'Every prison, every convoy, every rumor.'

'Not the right prison.'

'No.'

The single word held seven years of failure.

Evorn told him what had happened to Myca. Seressa had tortured her for three days, trying to learn where the Chalice had been taken. Myca escaped her chains long enough to

Fantasia II

destroy half the palace sanctuary. No body was found. Evorn believed she was dead.

Raevorn expected satisfaction. The woman who had replaced his mother was gone. Instead he remembered her refusing to move Erica's red flowers and felt something inside him twist.

Evorn spread maps across a table. The resistance had weakened Aetolia but could not win. The witches drew power from five provincial towers linked to the capital. Seressa controlled the western tower in Rytorn. If the Imprisoned infiltrating her palace discovered its defenses, Evorn planned to attack within a month.

'And after Rytorn?' Raevorn asked.

'We destroy the other towers. Then Smyr. Then Aetolia.'

'Aetolia itself?'

'They poisoned our kingdom at a wedding.'

'My mother was Aetolian.'

Evorn's jaw tightened. 'Your mother was Waland's queen.'

Fantasia II

'She was also a woman taken as a slave in your war.'

Silence entered the tent.

Raevorn had never dared say it before. Erica had loved him, but she had not chosen how her life in Waland began. The kingdom Evorn wanted restored had not been innocent.

'You sound like their teachers,' Evorn said.

'I sound like her son.'

That night the Stag King left without speaking to him.

Raevorn lay awake among soldiers who whispered that the prince had returned. He realized he had escaped one prison only to enter the expectations of another.

V - The Woman in Stone

Letha returned to Rytorn before sunrise. Raevorn insisted on going with her. Evorn refused, so Raevorn went anyway.

They entered disguised as charcoal sellers. At the palace, the Imprisoned statues remained where they had climbed three nights earlier. Letha knew which one had once been human: a small winged creature crouched above Seressa's study, its stone ears pressed to the wall.

At sunset the statues softened. Wings opened with the sound of grinding rock. The creature dropped into the abandoned stable where Letha waited. Its body was gray and child-sized, its mouth sealed by smooth skin. It communicated by scratching words into dust.

SERESSA KNOWS THE CHALICE IS NEAR.

'How?' Letha asked.

THE CHALICE CALLS TO WITCH-BLOOD.

Another message followed.

Fantasia II

MYCA LIVES.

Raevorn seized the creature's shoulders. 'Where?'

It wrote one word.

BELOW.

Seressa had kept Myca beneath the palace for seven years, neither alive nor dead in the ordinary sense. The witch used her as a living key to the western tower. Myca's magic, chained and siphoned, stabilized the network that fed power to Aetolia's occupation.

Raevorn felt shame burn through him. While he had hated Myca for replacing his mother, she had endured seven years of torment after helping Evorn escape.

They could not tell the camp by raven; Seressa watched the skies. Letha proposed taking Raevorn through the palace's service tunnels that very night. It was reckless. It was also their only chance before Seressa moved Myca.

In the tunnels they passed rooms of confiscated Waland relics, cells where alchemists tested poisons on prisoners,

Fantasia II

and a chamber filled with glass jars containing shadows that tapped against their lids.

They found Myca at the base of the tower.

She hung inside a cage of blue crystal, unchanged by time except for white hair floating around her face. Silver threads ran from her skin into the walls. Her eyes opened when Raevorn approached.

'Erica's boy,' she whispered.

He could not answer.

'You have her eyes when you are angry.'

'I am sorry,' he said.

Myca smiled weakly. 'For being fifteen?'

A door opened above them. Witch Seressa descended the spiral stair wearing a gown the color of old bruises. She was beautiful in the way ice was beautiful: clear, sharp, and indifferent to anything trapped beneath it.

Fantasia II

'Prince Raevorn,' she said. 'Your father has hidden from me for seven years. You walked into my house in seven days.'

Letha attacked. Seressa lifted one finger. Air struck Letha hard enough to break stone.

Raevorn's rusted sword melted in his hand.

Seressa looked at Myca. 'Tell him what the Chalice truly is.'

Myca closed her eyes.

'It is not a weapon,' Seressa continued. 'It is a prison built by the first witches to contain things that could not be killed. Every drinker opens the door a little. Every transformation lets something look back.'

VI - The Price of Monsters

Seressa offered Raevorn a bargain. He would lead her to the Chalice, and she would free Myca, spare Evorn, and grant Waland limited self-rule beneath Aetolia. She spoke gently, as though discussing tariffs rather than surrender.

Raevorn spat blood at her feet.

Seressa sighed. 'Your father did the same thing the first time I asked.'

Before she could bind him, the palace shook. Stone cracked overhead. The Imprisoned had begun their attack without Evorn's command. The winged spy tore through the chamber wall. A serpent made of roots wrapped itself around Seressa's legs. Somewhere above, soldiers screamed as statues came alive beneath their hands.

Letha, half-conscious, drove a broken blade into the crystal cage. Myca added the last of her strength. The cage burst.

Fantasia II

For one instant every silver thread went dark.

The western tower collapsed inward.

Magic flooded the chamber. Seressa became wind and flame, passing through roots and stone. Raevorn dragged Myca toward the tunnels while Letha covered them. The winged Imprisoned remained behind, scratching a final word into the floor before Seressa's fire consumed it.

RUN.

They escaped beneath falling streets. Rytorn's people poured from their homes as the palace split and the Aetolian banners burned. Resistance fighters entered through gates opened by servants. For the first time in seven years, Waland's blue flag rose over a city.

But Seressa escaped.

Myca survived only because Tavin brought the Chalice to Rytorn. Its presence steadied her failing magic. She awoke in a cellar and demanded that no one let Evorn drink from it again.

'Why?' Raevorn asked.

Fantasia II

'Because Seressa told the truth.'

Myca explained that the Chalice had been forged centuries ago from the heart-metal of a fallen star. The first witches used it to trap beings born before humanity: hungers, storms, instincts, and dreams with minds of their own. Transformation gave mortals a fragment of those beings. With every drink, the seals weakened.

'The Imprisoned are not merely changed,' she said. 'They are shared.'

Evorn entered before dawn, antlers cutting through the doorway. He saw Myca and became still.

For the first time Raevorn saw the cold king disappear. Evorn knelt beside her bed and pressed his forehead to her hand.

'I thought you were dead.'

'I was busy.'

His laugh became a sob.

Their reunion lasted less than a minute before messengers arrived. Seressa had ordered reprisals across the

Fantasia II

west. Villages suspected of aiding Rytorn were burning. Evorn rose with murder in his eyes.

'Give me the Chalice,' he told Tavin.

'No,' Myca said.

'I need more power.'

'You need more humanity.'

Evorn turned on her. The black veins around his eyes spread. For a heartbeat, something enormous looked through him.

Raevorn stepped between them.

'She said no.'

The Stag King's antlers scraped the ceiling as he leaned close to his son. Then, slowly, Evorn backed away.

'Rytorn is one city,' he said. 'Without power, we lose everything else.'

'With that power,' Raevorn replied, 'we may free Waland and release something worse.'

VII - A Prince of No Kingdom

Rytorn's liberation changed the war. It also split the resistance.

Evorn's commanders wanted to create hundreds of imprisoned and attack the remaining towers before Aetolia recovered. Myca and Tavin wanted the Chalice destroyed. Letha argued that neither plan mattered unless ordinary people joined the uprising; monsters could win battles, but they could not rebuild fields, courts, or trust.

Raevorn listened while people spoke around him as though his blood made him a verdict.

At last he said, 'I do not know enough to rule this argument.'

Several nobles looked offended. Evorn looked disappointed. Letha smiled.

Fantasia II

Raevorn spent the following weeks walking through liberated villages. He listened to farmers whose sons had been taken by Aetolian levies. He listened to Aetolian families who had settled in Waland and now feared revenge. He listened to former slaves who remembered that Waland's old nobility had not treated everyone kindly. The kingdom people wanted restored had existed differently for each of them.

In a burned village he met a girl named Sera whose brother had drunk from the Chalice and become a river fish with a human voice. The resistance used him to carry messages through waterways. Sera had not seen him in months.

'Is he a hero?' she asked Raevorn.

He thought of the winged spy dying beneath Seressa's fire. 'Yes.'

'Will he become my brother again?'

Raevorn could not lie. 'I don't know.'

That answer followed him.

Fantasia II

Seressa, meanwhile, joined the remaining four witches in Smyr. They began drawing power directly from the tower network. Summer storms froze orchards. Lightning hunted resistance camps. People dreamed the same dream of a silver cup overflowing with black water.

Myca believed the ancient beings inside the Chalice were waking. The witches wanted to seize it not merely to make dragons, but to command what lay beyond the seals.

Evorn planned a final march on Smyr before they could do so. His strategy required every Imprisoned to attack the towers simultaneously. Many would die at dawn if caught in exposed places.

'You are spending them,' Raevorn said.

'They volunteered.'

'For freedom, not disposal.'

'War disposes of everyone eventually.'

Raevorn stared at the man who had once carried him on his shoulders through the first snow. 'That is the thing inside you speaking.'

Fantasia II

Evorn struck him. The blow sent Raevorn across the tent.

Everyone froze.

Evorn looked at his own hand with horror, then hardened his face. 'Leave.'

Raevorn did. That night, he asked Tavin to show him the Chalice.

It was smaller than legend: tarnished silver, dented near the rim, engraved with figures pressing outward from the inside. When Raevorn touched it, he heard a thousand doors close.

'You want to drink,' Tavin said.

'I want to know what my father chose.'

'He chose life in a moment when death was certain. Do not mistake necessity for wisdom.'

Raevorn withdrew his hand.

'Can it be destroyed?'

'Myca thinks so. At the place it was forged: beneath Smyr.'

Fantasia II

The prison, Raevorn realized, had always been beneath the capital. The witches had built their conquest atop the very thing they feared.

VIII - The March of the Imprisoned

Evorn's army moved toward Smyr under a moonless sky. Men and women marched beside creatures from nightmare and fable: a bear with six eyes, a woman whose body dissolved into moths, a stag made of glass, a living oak carried in a wagon by its own roots. By day, some became stone. Others slept beneath soil or water. A few never rested at all and slowly forgot how to speak.

Raevorn rode with Letha at the rear. Myca traveled in a covered cart, still weak but able to shape small spells. Tavin guarded the Chalice inside an iron chest chained to his wrist.

They reached the first tower at midnight. Evorn's plan worked. Imprisoned infiltrators broke the wards, and Waland's soldiers overwhelmed the garrison. Then dawn came early.

Seressa had bent light across the horizon.

Fantasia II

Sunrise struck while dozens of Imprisoned were still on the tower walls. Stone bodies fell and shattered. Night-creatures burned. The living oak rooted itself over a group of soldiers and became a dead tree, protecting them as fire rained from above.

Evorn ordered the survivors onward.

Raevorn refused.

'We bury them,' he said.

'We lose hours.'

'They gave us years.'

Soldiers stopped. One by one, they lowered their weapons. Even commanders who feared Evorn joined the burial.

The Stag King stood alone beneath the false dawn. Blackness spread across his face. For a terrible moment Raevorn believed he would attack his own army.

Then Myca climbed from her cart and touched Evorn's antlered cheek.

Fantasia II

'Come back,' she whispered.

He shuddered. The darkness receded.

They buried the dead beneath the oak's branches and carved every name they knew into the tower stones.

The delay should have ruined them. Instead, villagers who witnessed the burial joined the march. News traveled ahead: the resistance remembered its monsters as people. By the time they reached the second tower, miners opened hidden roads. At the third, Aetolian conscripts abandoned their posts. At the fourth, citizens seized the lower gates before Evorn arrived.

Seressa retreated to Smyr with the other witches.

The capital appeared beneath storm clouds, surrounded by walls Raevorn remembered from childhood. Above the palace, a spiral of black weather turned around a point of silver light.

The Chalice began to sing inside its chest.

Every Imprisoned heard it. Some collapsed. Some turned toward the city with hunger that was not their own.

Fantasia II

Tavin unlocked the chain around his wrist. 'It is calling its pieces home.'

Myca looked at Raevorn. 'Once we enter, the beings inside may control anyone who has drunk.'

That included Evorn and half their strongest fighters.

'Then the rest of us must save them,' Raevorn said.

Evorn gave a bitter smile. 'You finally sound like a prince.'

'No,' Raevorn replied. 'I sound like Sera's brother.'

I X - S m y r

They attacked at dusk.

Letha led ordinary soldiers through the western gate while Imprisoned climbed towers and crossed the river beneath the surface. Myca shattered wards from a hill outside the walls. Tavin and Raevorn entered through the old royal crypts, carrying the Chalice toward the forge beneath the palace.

Smyr was both familiar and ruined. Raevorn passed the courtyard where he had learned swordplay, now filled with cages. He crossed the wedding hall, its murals painted over with Aetolian victories. White pigeons nested in the rafters.

At the sanctuary stairs, Seressa waited with four witches.

They had joined their bodies through magic. Fire moved beneath one woman's skin. Rain fell upward around another. A third breathed green vapor that made stone decay. The

Fantasia II

fourth held a chain of lightning. Seressa stood at the center, wearing Myca's stolen crown.

'You brought it home,' she said.

Tavin opened the iron chest.

The witches smiled.

Then Tavin threw the empty chest at them.

Letha had the Chalice.

She emerged from a side passage with Myca and a squad of soldiers. The deception bought only seconds, but seconds were enough for Myca to strike Seressa with seven years of stored pain.

Magic split the sanctuary.

Raevorn and Tavin ran downward while battle consumed the stairs. Beneath the palace they found the forge: a circular chamber carved into star-metal, older than every kingdom. At its center stood a black opening shaped like a mouth. The figures engraved on the Chalice moved now, pushing against the silver walls.

Fantasia II

Evorn dropped from the ceiling behind them.

His transformation had gone beyond the Stag King. Antlers branched into shadows. His arms ended in claws. Many voices spoke through his mouth.

GIVE US THE VESSEL.

Raevorn drew his sword though he knew steel meant nothing.

'Father.'

The creature advanced.

Tavin whispered, 'The forge will destroy the Chalice, but it may also kill everyone connected to it.'

That meant Evorn. The Imprisoned. Perhaps Myca, whose soul had shaped the cup.

Above them the city shook. If they hesitated, the witches would take the Chalice. If they destroyed it, Waland might be freed by the death of those who had saved it.

Fantasia II

Raevorn understood at last why every choice in war felt like a prison: each closed around the people one refused to abandon.

He lowered his sword.

'You searched every prison for me,' he told Evorn. 'Now I will search this one for you.'

He stepped forward and embraced the monster.

Claws pierced his back. Voices screamed inside his skull. He saw fragments of what lived beyond the Chalice: endless hunger wearing the memory of beasts; storms dreaming of bodies; ancient loneliness that wanted the world simply because it could not enter it.

Beneath them, buried under all that noise, he found Evorn.

His father knelt in snow beside Erica's deathbed. He stood helpless outside Raevorn's empty cell. He held Myca's bloodied hand. He carried every dead soldier as a weight and had mistaken becoming heavier for becoming stronger.

'Let go,' Raevorn said.

Fantasia II

'Then I am only a man who failed.'

'Be that man.'

Evorn began to weep.

The Stag King released Raevorn and seized the Chalice.
With his last human strength, he hurled it into the forge.

X - The Breaking of the Chalice

The Chalice did not melt. It screamed.

Silver unfolded into a doorway filled with black stars. The ancient beings surged toward the opening, dragging on every soul linked to them. Across Smyr, Imprisoned fell. Some became human for a heartbeat. Others transformed wildly, fur to stone to flame to flesh.

Myca reached the forge as Seressa descended behind her. The witch's stolen crown burned white.

'Fools!' Seressa cried. 'You could command gods.'

'No,' Myca said. 'Only prisoners.'

She joined her magic to the forge, but the doorway widened. The Chalice had been fed too many lives. It could not simply be destroyed; the bond had to be returned willingly by everyone who carried it.

Fantasia II

Raevorn climbed the stairs into the sanctuary and shouted the truth to the battlefield. Letha repeated it from the palace balcony. Messengers carried the words through the city: the Imprisoned could release their power, but they might die or become ordinary, broken bodies again.

The choice spread from creature to creature.

The glass stag shattered itself. Light poured from every fragment toward the forge. The woman of moths gathered into human form and whispered her own name before vanishing. The river fish spoke farewell to the current. Stone spies cracked open. The old living oak released a green flame from its roots.

Not all chose release. Some feared death. Some had forgotten enough of humanity that power was all they knew. Raevorn did not condemn them. Freedom offered under threat was another prison.

Evorn stood before the doorway, holding it back with antlers and claws. One by one, his monstrous features burned away.

Fantasia II

Seressa attacked Myca from behind. Tavin stepped between them. The witch's green vapor passed through his chest.

The coward did not move aside.

With his final breath, he drove an alchemical needle into Seressa's wrist. The poison had been made from seven years of studying witch-blood. Her magic collapsed. Myca tore the crown from her head and cast it into the forge.

Seressa reached after it. The doorway recognized the hunger in her and pulled her inside.

The remaining witches fled or surrendered as the tower network went dark.

At the forge, Evorn became human. He was older, wounded, and suddenly small without the shadow around him. Raevorn caught him before he fell.

'Did we win?' Evorn asked.

'The city is ours.'

'That is not what I asked.'

Fantasia II

Raevorn looked at Myca, at Letha carrying Tavin's body, at former monsters waking confused among soldiers who called them by their names. Outside, Walanders and Aetolians were both pulling survivors from ruins.

'Not yet,' he said. 'But we stopped losing ourselves.'

Evorn smiled. Then his eyes closed.

He did not wake again.

XI - What Freedom Keeps

The liberation of Smyr ended the occupation, but peace did not arrive like sunlight. It came as work.

Some Aetolian garrisons surrendered. Others fought for months. Villages demanded revenge. Nobles returned from exile expecting their estates and titles restored. Former servants occupied those estates and refused to leave. The old laws of Waland resurfaced beside the new wounds of conquest.

Raevorn was crowned in the same church where Evorn and Myca had married. He refused the ancient oath promising that Waland belonged to its king. Instead he swore that the king belonged to Waland, and that Waland belonged equally to those who lived within it, whether their grandparents had been born north or south of the mountains.

Fantasia II

Half the nobility called it weakness. The other half called it blasphemy. Common people mostly wanted grain prices lowered.

Myca became keeper of the broken forge. Though the Chalice was gone, fragments of star-metal remained dangerous. She established an order to study magic without ownership of human lives. In honor of Tavin, its first rule was that fear did not cancel courage.

Letha became commander of a new city guard composed of former resistance fighters, Aetolian deserters, and citizens. She rejected every title Raevorn offered until he invented one she disliked less.

The surviving Imprisoned faced uncertain fates. Some returned fully human. Some retained altered bodies or strange abilities. A few could still move only at night. Raevorn granted them land, pensions, and the legal right to their own names and forms. No one was permitted to call them weapons in royal documents.

Sera's brother was found in the river south of Smyr. When the Chalice broke, he became human while swimming

Fantasia II

and nearly drowned. He returned home coughing, naked, and furious that everyone had believed fish did not understand jokes.

Myca planted red Aetolian flowers beneath the palace windows. Raevorn helped her, though neither spoke of Erica until the final seed was covered.

'Did she ever love him?' Raevorn asked.

Myca considered the soil on her hands. 'Not as he wanted. Perhaps not as stories demand. But love is not one country with one border. She cared for him. She forgave some things. She never forgave others.'

'And you?'

'I loved the man he was, the monster he became, and the man who returned for one minute at the end. It was inconvenient.'

Raevorn laughed. It surprised him how much the sound resembled his father's.

He ordered a memorial built not only for Waland's dead but for every person killed in the invasion and the wars

Fantasia II

before it, including Aetolian prisoners taken in his grandfather's campaigns. On the central stone he had one sentence carved:

NO KINGDOM IS FREE WHILE IT NEEDS
SOMEONE ELSE IN CHAINS.

People argued about the words for generations. Raevorn considered that a sign they were useful.

Epilogue - Dawn Without Stone

Years later, children played among the statues on the roof of the old palace at Rytorn.

Most were ordinary carvings now, placed there in memory of the spies who had listened through stone. One statue remained different: a small winged creature crouched above the former witch's study. No sculptor admitted making it. At sunset, birds sometimes gathered around its shoulders.

Raevorn visited on the anniversary of the city's liberation. He was no longer the thin young man who had crawled from the sea, though prison remained in the way he checked every room for windows. Letha accompanied him, complaining that kings should not climb roofs without guards while climbing faster than he did.

They sat beside the winged statue as dawn approached.

'Do you ever think it is still listening?' Raevorn asked.

Fantasia II

'Constantly,' Letha said. 'That is why I only say flattering things near it.'

The first light touched the stone.

For an instant, Raevorn felt certain that one wing moved.

Below them, Rytorn awakened. Foundries opened. Bakers carried bread into streets once patrolled by witches. Aetolian and Waland children argued over a ball. In the river, silver fish flashed beneath the surface, entirely ordinary and therefore miraculous.

Raevorn had once believed freedom meant escaping a cell. Later he thought it meant defeating an enemy. Now he understood that freedom was a practice: the daily refusal to turn fear into chains, grief into cruelty, or power into permission.

The sun rose over Waland.

Nothing turned to stone.

Fantasia II

Soul

The Story of Soul

Prologue: The Market of Selves

In the city of Lyr, no one was expected to remain entirely themselves.kc

On every avenue, polished towers advertised permanent revisions of character: courage without recklessness, ambition without guilt, devotion without grief. Beneath them, in alleys bright with paper lanterns, travelling merchants sold smaller changes from carts and folding tables. A vial could quiet jealousy for an evening. A silver patch might make a shy person dazzling at a banquet. A whispered sequence, carried by a telepathic tuning fork, could lend a soldier patience or a gambler caution until sunrise.

People still spoke of souls, but rarely as mysteries. A soul was chemistry, memory, habit, attention and desire arranged in a living pattern. It could be measured, copied, edited and sold.

The largest companies insisted that this had liberated humanity. No one had to endure a cruel temper inherited from a parent, a terror born in childhood or a sadness with no visible cause. Their critics replied that freedom purchased in monthly installments was merely another kind of obedience.

Fantasia II

Saen had no time for either argument. He was twenty-seven, perpetually short of money and gifted enough to understand that nearly everyone above him was less clever and far better connected.

He travelled with Orro, a merchant whose wagon bore the fading words ORRO'S ETHICAL ADJUSTMENTS. The word ethical had been painted larger after a dispute in the southern provinces.

Orro sold temporary souls. Saen designed them.

Together they moved from town to town, repairing fear, sharpening concentration, softening heartbreak and occasionally undoing the work of less careful merchants. Their customers paid in coin, food, fuel or promises. Most promises proved chemically inert.

Yet each night, when Orro slept beneath the wagon and the last borrowed personality had faded from the day's customers, Saen worked on something no corporation had dared to announce.

He was designing a soul that could travel.

I - A Gentle Algorithm

The first version of Saen's program occupied three glass cylinders, two copper crowns and a block of memory crystal that became dangerously warm whenever he thought about his mother.

He called it the Kindness Lattice.

The name embarrassed him, so he never said it aloud.

Ordinary soul programs altered one mind. Telepathy allowed two minds to exchange words, sensations or images. Saen's invention joined the two disciplines. A person carrying the Lattice could offer a chosen pattern of feeling to another person. If the second mind accepted, its chemistry would reorganize itself around the offered state.

Not obedience, Saen told himself. Not control. An invitation.

He built the core pattern from hundreds of observations. Kindness was not one emotion. It was attention without hunger, power restrained by imagination, and the ability to recognize another person's pain as real even when it was inconvenient. He studied healers, patient teachers, farmers who cared for old animals and strangers who returned lost purses when no one was watching.

The resulting program was not a single personality. It

Fantasia II

was a root from which many forms of gentleness could grow.

One rainy evening, in a field outside the town of Esren, Saen finally completed it.

Orro watched him fasten the copper crown around his head.

"You tested the rejection locks?" the merchant asked.

"Seven times."

"And the consent gate?"

"Twelve."

"How many times did you test whether it melts your brain?"

Saen looked at him.

"That was included in the seven."

"Comforting."

The activation felt like cold rain passing through his skull. For one breath he heard every insect in the field as though each possessed a tiny bell. Then came silence.

Saen opened his eyes.

Nothing had changed.

Orro leaned closer. "Are you kind now?"

"Apparently not enough to tolerate that question."

They laughed, relieved. Then Saen noticed a beetle struggling upside down in the mud. He had seen such things all his life. This time the creature's frantic legs seemed urgent, particular and impossible to ignore.

He turned it over with one finger.

Fantasia II

The act was trivial. The feeling was not.
The Lattice had worked.

II - The Unlocked Door

The next morning, Saen discovered that the consent gate did not exist.

Or rather, it existed perfectly in the program and failed completely in reality.

He learned this while watching a butcher strike a tired apprentice for dropping a tray. Anger rose in Saen, followed by a reflexive thought: Be gentler.

The thought left him.

He felt it cross the street like warmth through sunlight.

The butcher froze. His raised hand lowered. He stared at the frightened boy, then at his own fingers.

"Go wash the cut," he muttered. "I'll finish here."

Saen stumbled backward.

The butcher had not accepted anything. He had not even known Saen was there.

For the rest of the day Saen tested the edge of the phenomenon with increasing horror. Distance offered little protection. Names, faces and strong memories were enough to form a telepathic path. He could not rewrite complex beliefs in an instant, but he could strengthen or weaken emotional tendencies. He could quiet spite, awaken sympathy, soften disgust or make patience feel rewarding.

Fantasia II

He should have erased the program immediately.

Instead, he used it again.

A landlady stopped humiliating a widow over late rent. A gang of boys carried an injured dog to a healer. A wealthy traveller gave his unused blankets to families sleeping beneath an aqueduct. Saen altered each person differently. One became tender toward animals. Another found peace in solitude and no longer sought pleasure in mocking others. A third gained no warmth at all, only an austere conviction that every person deserved dignity.

The results were beautiful.

That beauty frightened him more than failure would have.

"You are stealing decisions," Orro said when Saen confessed.

"I'm removing cruelty."

"Cruel people say the same thing about removing weakness."

Saen paced beside the wagon. "What am I supposed to do? Pretend this doesn't exist? Someone else will discover it. Maybe someone already has."

"Then bury it."

"A buried knife still cuts when found."

Orro studied him for a long time. "And a man holding a knife eventually invents a reason to use it."

Saen promised he would stop.

For three days, he did.

III - Calypso

Calypso Soulworks occupied the tallest building in Lyr, a smooth white tower without visible doors.

Its advertisements called it the guardian of authentic transformation. Its critics called it a government with better tailoring.

Saen arrived carrying the Lattice in a black case. He had convinced himself that secrecy was more dangerous than disclosure. A corporation with laboratories, regulators and trained ethicists could contain the discovery. Calypso could build protections. It could make the consent gate real.

The reception hall smelled faintly of citrus and clean metal. Everyone inside wore the calm expression of people whose anxiety had been professionally removed.

Saen presented his work to six executives in a room overlooking the city. He explained the architecture, the kindness root and the catastrophic failure of consent.

For several seconds no one spoke.

Then Director Maelor laughed.

The others joined him.

It was not disbelief. It was recognition.

"You thought you were first," Maelor said.

Saen felt the floor tilt beneath him.

Fantasia II

"How long?"

"Long enough."

"You can alter people remotely?"

"Certain clients can. Carefully screened clients. Heads of state. Security ministers. A few private patrons."

"People who pay enough."

Maelor smiled. "Responsibility is expensive."

Saen reached for the Lattice in his mind and pushed calm toward the executives. The impulse struck something invisible and vanished.

Every person in the room wore a neural shield.

The doors opened. Officers entered.

Maelor folded his hands. "Unlicensed coercive soulcraft carries a sentence of permanent identity suspension. Fortunately, Calypso is authorized to perform the suspension."

Saen threw the black case through the window.

The glass had been programmed to resist bullets, fire and telepathic intrusion. It had not been programmed to resist a memory crystal tuned to resonate with its own molecular calm. The window relaxed into sand.

Wind exploded through the room.

Saen jumped onto a maintenance ledge, slid down a rain channel and escaped into the market below.

He left every instrument behind except the program already living in his brain.

I V - A Gift Without Permission

Orro found Saen beneath the old eastern viaduct, vomiting from neural exhaustion.

"I assume the meeting went well," the merchant said.

Saen gave him the backup crystal.

"Spread it."

Orro's face hardened. "No."

"Calypso already has the power. The police have it. Governments probably have it. Ordinary people are defenceless."

"So you intend to arm everyone with the same weapon?"

"The Lattice makes kindness the foundation."

"Foundation is not a roof."

Saen gripped his shoulders. "Use it on as many people as you can. Once they carry the program, no one can change them without resistance. They can feel the intrusion and push back."

Orro looked at the crystal as if it contained a sleeping plague.

"You built a lock," he said, "and accidentally made it a sword. Now you want to hand swords to a city because the palace has cannons."

Fantasia II

"Yes."

The honesty silenced them both.

Orro finally took the crystal.

"Go," he said. "I'll decide what to do after you're far enough away that I can't strangle you."

Saen took the merchant's motor carriage and drove toward the northern border.

He made it eighty kilometres.

Police barriers unfolded from the road like black iron flowers. Officers surrounded the vehicle. Saen tried to touch their minds and found only mirrored walls.

They returned him to Calypso.

This time Maelor received him in a windowless chamber.

"What was your plan?" the director asked.

Saen's wrists were locked to a steel table. "One interconnected mind. Not one personality. A network of people able to understand and care for one another without losing themselves."

"Our goals are not dissimilar."

"You sell domination."

"We regulate power. Badly, perhaps. But structure is the difference between civilization and contagion. Work with us, and you may live. Refuse, and we will erase every path in your mind that leads back to Saen."

An explosion shook the room.

A second followed, closer.

Fantasia II

The lights dimmed. Somewhere above them, hundreds of people began screaming, laughing and singing at once.

Maelor's composure cracked.

Saen understood before anyone spoke.

Orro had made his decision.

V - The Kindly War

The Kindness Lattice spread through Lyr in less than a day.

Orro had not sold it. He had given copies to healers, teachers, street organizers and every temporary soul merchant he trusted. Those people copied it again. By sunset, thousands carried the program.

By midnight, they had begun changing one another.

The first reports sounded miraculous. Soldiers abandoned an eviction. A magistrate confessed to taking bribes. Rival neighbourhoods opened their food stores to each other.

Then interpretation began.

A woman who believed kindness meant freedom stripped fear from every prisoner in a city jail. A priest convinced that peace required purity dampened the anger of an entire district until its residents could not defend themselves. A grieving father made strangers love his dead daughter so intensely that they crowded her tomb and refused to leave.

People altered friends during arguments. Lovers increased devotion. Parents reduced disobedience. Activists sharpened outrage in crowds they considered too passive.

Fantasia II

Some changes were gentle. Others were monstrous while wearing gentle names.

The city became a battlefield without visible weapons.

Policemen turned on commanders, then on one another. Calypso agents imposed discipline only to have it replaced by ecstatic compassion, paralysing serenity or fanatic protectiveness. Every mind became territory.

Maelor unlocked Saen's restraints.

"Fix it."

"You said you had experts."

"We have experts in control. This is something else."

They brought Saen to the tower's central laboratory. Through reinforced windows he watched Lyr convulse. Fires burned in three districts. Crowds carried the injured toward hospitals while other crowds blocked the roads because they had been made incapable of mistrust.

Saen reached outward and felt the city.

Millions of emotional instructions collided in the telepathic field. Kindness had not united anyone. It had multiplied every person's private definition of goodness and given that definition hands.

He thought of Orro's warning.

Foundation is not a roof.

"I need everyone asleep," Saen said.

Maelor stared at him. "Everyone?"

"Long enough to remove the transmission layer."

"How?"

Fantasia II

Saen looked toward the city reservoirs, food depots and climate ducts.

"Chemistry.

VI - The Sleeping City

Calypso possessed compounds capable of inducing sleep without lasting harm. It also possessed emergency access to nearly every supply chain in Lyr, a fact Maelor described as prudent contingency planning and Saen described with several less polite words.

They worked for thirty hours.

Saen designed a sequence that would make the Lattice interpret drowsiness as an act of self-protection rather than an attack. Calypso chemists prepared vapours and additives. Remaining city officials broadcast warnings about a temporary medical measure, though few citizens trusted any voice long enough to listen.

Rain began near dusk.

The compound entered public fountains, heating systems, bakeries and the misting towers used to cool crowded streets. Sleep moved through Lyr district by district.

People collapsed at dinner tables, in doorways and beneath statues. Fighters lowered their hands. Officers slid against walls. A crowd singing outside Calypso slowed until the song became a murmur and then breath.

Saen walked through the sleeping city wearing a neural crown linked to the central telepathic grid.

Fantasia II

One by one, he touched the minds around him and removed the uncontrolled transmission function. He did not erase the kindness root. He left the heightened capacity for empathy, patience and mutual recognition. But he took away the ability to impose changes without consent.

It was the largest soul operation ever attempted.

For three days, Saen barely moved. Nurses fed him through a tube. Blood ran from his nose. Memories escaped their proper rooms: he smelled his childhood home while standing in a laboratory; he called Maelor by Orro's name; once, he forgot which body was his.

At the centre of the sleeping network he found something unexpected.

The citizens of Lyr were not becoming one mind, yet their dreams overlapped. A frightened child dreamed of a harbour, and an old sailor across the city dreamed himself there beside her. A prisoner dreamed of forgiveness, and the magistrate who had sentenced him woke weeping.

Connection had formed without command.

Saen realized then that the power itself had never been the bridge.

Listening was.

VII - The Price of Rescue

Lyr awoke slowly.

No one was unchanged.

Some remembered altering loved ones and could no longer bear to meet their eyes. Others mourned the loss of power, insisting that they had used it responsibly. Thousands filed complaints against Calypso for drugging the city. Thousands more thanked it. Several attempted to burn the tower down before breakfast.

Orro was found asleep in a tram station with three broken ribs and a bag full of empty memory crystals.

When he saw Saen, he punched him.

Then he embraced him.

"I was wrong to spread it," Orro said.

"I was wrong to ask."

"Good. I would hate to have damaged your famous arrogance for nothing."

Maelor offered Saen a position at Calypso.

The offer included a laboratory, legal immunity and a salary large enough to make principles feel unexpectedly negotiable.

Saen refused twice.

On the third occasion, Maelor showed him intelligence

Fantasia II

reports from across the continent. News of the Lattice had escaped Lyr. Governments demanded access. Corporations were reverse-engineering fragments. Underground soulwrights promised power without waiting lists or moral lectures.

The secret was dead.

"You can stand outside and condemn us," Maelor said, "or remain inside and make us less terrible."

"That is the sentence every terrible institution uses to recruit decent people."

"Often because it works."

Saen accepted under conditions: all research would be independently audited; coercive soulcraft would be exposed to the public; and no program would be released without a consent architecture that could not be bypassed by Calypso itself.

Maelor agreed with suspicious ease.

Saen added one final condition.

Orro would oversee public complaints.

Maelor's face suggested that permanent identity suspension might have been kinder.

VIII - The Demand

The truth changed the world faster than the technology had.

Once people learned that elites had possessed remote soulcraft for years, anger spread across every kingdom. Protesters surrounded corporate towers. Legislatures collapsed. Officers refused orders after wondering whether loyalty had been installed. Husbands questioned love, disciples questioned faith and citizens questioned patriotism.

The same demand appeared in every city:

If this power exists, it belongs to everyone.

Riots followed. So did revolutions.

Calypso proposed licensing only governments and major institutions. The proposal lasted eleven minutes before someone threw a statue through the conference window.

Saen argued for education.

Not a test of obedience. Not wealth disguised as merit. A public curriculum in psychology, ethics, history, consent, conflict, trauma and the limits of one's own certainty. Students would practise only with simulations and with temporary, reversible states. They would learn to recognize coercion, resist intrusion and understand that feeling kind did not make an action just.

Fantasia II

Those who completed the program could receive the full consensual Lattice at no cost.

The plan satisfied almost no one, which Orro considered evidence that it might be reasonable.

Governments built academies. Corporations opened rival programs. Communities created their own schools in temples, warehouses and abandoned train stations. Some were excellent. Some were propaganda camps with attractive brochures.

Saen spent years arguing over standards.

He became famous, then hated, then fashionable, then boring. Children wore imitation copper crowns. Politicians quoted him inaccurately. Conspiracy pamphlets claimed he had been replaced by seven coordinated souls working in shifts.

Through it all, the program improved.

The consent gate became mutual: both minds could inspect the intended change before accepting. Every alteration carried a visible history. No one could delete discomfort without also seeing what that discomfort protected. No one could manufacture love, only remove barriers to feelings already present.

Most importantly, the Lattice taught refusal.

A connected world, Saen came to understand, required people capable of saying no.

IX - Thirty Years

Thirty years after the sleeping of Lyr, soulcraft had become as ordinary as literacy.

Most adults carried some version of the Lattice. They could share calm during disasters, lend courage to a frightened speaker, soften panic before surgery or allow another person to feel the precise shape of an apology. Couples used it carefully. Diplomats used it under public observation. Teachers used it only after students learned how to close their minds.

War did not vanish.

Neither did greed, cruelty or stupidity.

But deception became harder when another person could request the emotional history behind a promise. Soldiers who shared fear with enemies found killing more difficult. Judges could not erase bias, but they could expose it to themselves. Communities coordinated labour with a depth of understanding once available only to close families.

There were failures. Entire regions rejected the Lattice. Some people abused legal programs or built illegal ones. A movement called the Singulars argued that unmodified solitude was sacred. Saen defended their right to remain disconnected, to the fury of admirers who had mistaken unity

Fantasia II

for compulsory agreement.

Calypso changed too. It became partly public, partly cooperative and entirely burdened by committees. Maelor retired, insisting that bureaucracy was the final punishment for surviving one's ambitions.

Orro grew old in comfort and complained about it constantly.

Saen's hair turned white at the temples. His hands shook when he worked too long. He had spent half his life constructing what younger developers now criticized as primitive.

He loved them for it.

One evening, he returned to the eastern viaduct where he had once handed Orro the backup crystal.

The city around him was quiet. Not silent—never silent—but connected by countless voluntary threads. Someone grieving in a nearby apartment sent out a request for company. Five strangers accepted. A baker shared the contentment of fresh bread with the night workers on her street. Two former enemies exchanged memories and discovered that understanding did not require forgiveness, only honesty.

Saen opened his mind.

Millions of presences shimmered at the edge of awareness, each distinct, each capable of retreat. They were not one personality. They did not think the same thoughts or desire the same things.

Fantasia II

They were something more difficult and more beautiful:
many souls choosing, again and again, not to be alone.

Epilogue: One Soul

The old dream had been wrong in one important way.

Humanity did not become a single Soul because everyone was made kind.

Kindness could be imposed, and imposed kindness was merely domination wearing a gentle face. Nor did humanity unite because conflict ended. Conflict remained wherever people loved different things, remembered different wounds or imagined different futures.

The great Soul emerged from the space between them.

It lived in every offered feeling that could be refused, every memory shared without being stolen, every moment when power paused and asked permission. It was not a ruler above humanity but a practice among human beings.

On the final day of Orro's life, Saen sat beside his bed.

"Did we save the world?" the old merchant asked.

"Parts of it. Temporarily."

"Excellent. Permanent work is exhausting."

Orro extended a trembling hand. Saen accepted the connection.

He felt the road beneath the wagon, rain on canvas, bad soup, unpaid debts, the terror of the first crystal and the stubborn affection Orro had hidden beneath thirty years of

Fantasia II

insults. Saen offered his own memories in return.

Nothing was changed.

Nothing needed to be.

When Orro died, those memories remained in Saen and in everyone the old merchant had willingly touched. They did not replace grief. They gave it company.

That night, bells sounded across Lyr. People paused wherever they were and opened their minds—not because a law required it, not because a corporation sold it, but because they chose to.

For one breath, Saen felt the world listening to itself.

It was vast, quarrelsome, wounded, hilarious and alive.
And it loved.